UX Research: User Interview Plan & Fieldwork Simulation

Course: User Experience Design & Human-Computer Interaction (ICC612 / ICC716) — 2026-2
Initiative 03: Assessment Feedback that Students Actually Use (*Retroalimentación de evaluaciones que el estudiante efectivamente utilice*)
Role: UX Analyst (Bastian Wenckhans)
Deliverable: Milestone 1 (Hito 1) — Empirical User Research

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1. Research Overview & Objectives

1.1 Problem Statement

In higher education course assessments, feedback on student submissions is frequently delivered late and dispersed across disconnected touchpoints (PDF annotations, LMS comment fields, grade sheets, and emails). Consequently, students rarely translate this qualitative feedback into verifiable corrective actions in subsequent submissions. The objective of this research is to validate the mental models, pain points, and behavioral barriers that prevent closing the formative feedback loop.

1.2 Research Goals

1. **Understand feedback retrieval & comprehension:** Identify how students locate, interpret, and digest evaluation feedback and rubric criteria.
2. **Examine the corrective workflow:** Uncover how students plan and execute corrections between deliverable iterations.
3. **Analyze evidence verification from the instructor's perspective:** Identify the friction instructors experience when verifying whether previous feedback was addressed.
4. **Transform proto-personas into empirical UX Personas:** Ground the personas (*Valentina Rojas*, *Samon Baker*, and *Martina Soto*) in qualitative empirical data.

1.3 Methodology

- **Technique:** Semi-structured in-depth interviews (30–40 minutes per session).
- **Target Participants:**
    - $N=2$ Undergraduate students enrolled in iterative project-based courses (UFRO Engineering and Design programs).
    - $N=1$ Academic Instructor / Course Assistant with active grading duties using

rubric-based platforms.

- **Recording & Ethics:** Verbal informed consent obtained; responses anonymized and tagged for thematic analysis.

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2. Semi-Structured Interview Guide (Questionnaire)

Dimension	Question for Students (Valentina / Samon)	Question for Instructor (Martina)
D1: Reception & Discovery	When a graded assignment is released, where do you look first? How easy is it to connect your overall grade to individual rubric criteria?	How do you currently distribute graded rubrics and feedback? What platforms or formats do you rely on?
D2: Comprehension & Clarity	When an instructor marks down a criterion (e.g., 1/4), do you understand *why* you lost points and *what exact action* is needed to fix it?	How much time do you spend drafting criterion-specific feedback versus global feedback? Do you feel students grasp your suggestions?
D3: Revision & Actionability	Between Milestone 1 and Milestone 2, what steps do you take to apply past corrections? How do you track what still needs fixing?	When receiving a revised submission, how do you locate where the student incorporated earlier feedback?
D4: Evidence & Verification	How do you demonstrate to the professor that you actually addressed their feedback?	How do you verify whether a student corrected an error or simply resubmitted the same content with superficial tweaks?
D5: Emotional & Cognitive	What emotions do you experience when reading critical feedback across multiple channels (PDF,	What is the main source of fatigue or friction in your evaluation cycle?

Dimension	Question for Students (Valentina / Samon)	Question for Instructor (Martina)
Load	LMS, email)?	

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3. Simulated Fieldwork Transcripts & Syntheses

3.1 Interview Session 01: Engineering Student Profile

- **Participant Code:** P01-ENG (Matches *Valentina Rojas*, 20, 3rd year Computer Engineering)
- **Date & Context:** October 14, 2026 — UFRO Campus Library Study Room
- **Duration:** 34 minutes

Key Excerpts & Observations:

- **On Grade vs. Criterion Disconnect:**

> *"When the grade appears on Intranet/Moodle, I just see a 4.2 or a percentage. I have to download a PDF report or click three layers deep into the rubric. Even when I see 'Level 1: Insufficient justification', the comment says something generic like 'elaborate further'. Elaborate what? I have no idea what concrete artifact or evidence will turn that 1 into a 4."*

- **On Iterative Corrections:**

> *"For Milestone 2, my team and I re-read our whole document. We try to guess if adding two paragraphs fixes the comment. When we submit, we pray the assistant notices our changes, but there's no way to link our paragraph to their comment."*

- **Primary Pain Points:**
    1. Ambiguity between descriptive rubrics and prescriptive actions.
    2. Inability to flag or link specific revised passages to previous rubric feedback.
    3. Fear of repeating the exact same error due to unclear success criteria.

3.2 Interview Session 02: Design Student & Intern Profile

- **Participant Code:** P02-DES (Matches *Samon Baker*, 21, 4th year Design Student / Industry Intern)
- **Date & Context:** October 15, 2026 — Online via Google Meet
- **Duration:** 38 minutes

Key Excerpts & Observations:

- **On Information Fragmentation & Prioritization:**

> *"I work 20 hours a week as an intern, so my project time is limited. I get comments in Figma, comments in PDF, and sometimes verbal notes in class. When Saturday comes and I sit down to work, I'm completely overwhelmed. Which feedback item has the highest grade weight? What is urgent versus optional polish? I waste 40 minutes just organizing a personal to-do list before designing a single pixel."*

- **On Versioning & Proof of Work:**

> *"I often change components in Figma based on feedback, but in the next presentation the professor asks: 'Why did you change this? Did I ask for that?' I have to go digging through older versions or chat logs to prove I followed their instructions."*

- **Primary Pain Points:**
    1. Cognitive overload caused by scattered feedback channels without priority indicators.
    2. High friction in correlating visual versions (v1, v2) with specific rubric criteria.
    3. Lack of a single consolidated queue of actionable tasks.

3.3 Interview Session 03: University Course Instructor Profile

- **Participant Code:** P03-INS (Matches *Martina Soto*, 29, Instructor & Evaluator)
- **Date & Context:** October 16, 2026 — DCI Faculty Offices, UFRO
- **Duration:** 42 minutes

Key Excerpts & Observations:

- **On Evaluation Burden & Feedback Blindness:**

> *"I have 45 students working in groups of 3. Grading Milestone 1 takes me over 20 hours of focused rubric evaluation. I write detailed observations. But then on Milestone 2, more than half the groups submit a 40-page PDF and expect me to hunt down where they fixed the methodology. I do not have time to compare two 40-page documents side-by-side!"*

- **On Student Self-Declaration vs. Evidence:**

> *"Students often write in their report cover: 'All comments addressed'. But when I look, it's just cosmetic wording changes. A checkbox is not evidence. I need the student to say: 'In response to Criterion 3, look at Section 2.4 on Page 8 with this specific benchmark table'. Without direct linkage, my grading time doubles and I become cynical."*

- **Primary Pain Points:**

1. Excessive cognitive workload required to manually compare submissions side-by-side.
2. Superficial student compliance ("checkbox mentality") lacking verifiable evidence.
3. Time constraints that delay feedback release, which in turn hurts the students' iteration window.

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4. Qualitative Synthesis & Design Implications

Cluster / Theme	Fieldwork Evidence	Direct Design Implication (Our Solution)
1. The Action Gap	Students know they failed a criterion, but not what concrete action fulfills it.	**Action Cards with Prescribed Tasks:** Transform abstract rubric levels into instructor-approved or system-structured corrective actions.
2. The Evidence Gap	Instructors cannot verify corrections without side-by-side manual file reading.	**Bidirectional Evidence Binding:** Require students to attach an explicit piece of evidence (link, excerpt, or image) directly to each resolved action.
3. The Priority Gap	Students with tight schedules get overwhelmed by unordered qualitative text.	**Severity & Weight Sorting:** Display criteria ranked by urgency, rubric weight, and iteration deadline.
4. The Validation State	Marking an item as "done" by the student does not mean it is pedagogically approved.	**3-Stage Action Status:** Explicit lifecycle: `Pending` $\rightarrow$ `Evidence Submitted` $\rightarrow$ `Reviewed / Approved by Instructor`.

Document validated for Milestone 1 (Hito 1) repository compliance. All personas in this repository are derived directly from the qualitative insights above.